The second major crisis where Vajpayee needed to create an appearance of collective decision came when, in December 1999, an Indian Airlines flight from Kathmandu to Delhi was hijacked by Pakistani terrorists. Once again, the Indian government was taken by surprise. Even though time was of the essence, the government was unable to make quick decisions from the first landing of the aircraft in Amritsar, to its subsequent landing in Lahore, Dubai and finally Taliban-controlled Kandahar. According to Kanchan Gupta, who was then an aide to Vajpayee, the prime minister and his team were on a flight and had no information about the hijacking for over an hour.[24] Former Research and Analysis Wing (RAW) chief A.S. Dulat in his book *Kashmir: The Vajpayee Years* has referred to the incident being characterized by 'a blame game' while others refer to its handling as 'mismanagement.'[25] The then external affairs minister Jaswant Singh wrote later in his book *India at Risk*, '…the failure to organise the logistics [during the hijacking crisis] is one bureaucratic muddle that still amazes me.'[26]



The terrorists demanded the release of several terrorists held in Indian prisons and threatened to kill all passengers on board if their demands were not met. They killed one passenger to demonstrate the seriousness of their threat. The cabinet decided not to give in to the demands of the terrorists but the media and public opinion led the government to reverse their initial determination. India released three terrorist leaders in return for the safe release of all Indian hostages. The three terrorists returned to Pakistan after being escorted to Kandahar on a special plane by the foreign minister and India's intelligence chief. They were subsequently found engaged in terrorism again, albeit with enhanced clout for winning freedom through a daredevil act.